

Wonderful caterpillars

Caterpillars can be hairy or spiny, and have unusual shapes.



Cabbage white caterpillar



Tiger moth caterpillar



Emperor moth caterpillar



Puss moth caterpillar

Like most insects, caterpillars breathe through openings called spiracles.

The five pairs of stumpy, suckerlike legs are called prolegs. The caterpillar uses them for holding onto plant stalks.



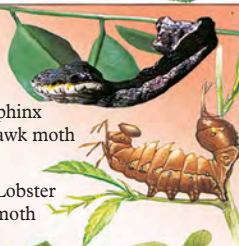
Masters of disguise

To avoid being eaten, some caterpillars have developed crafty disguises. The sphinx hawk moth caterpillar looks like a deadly snake, the lobster moth looks like a raised lobster's claw, and the common sailer looks like a shriveled leaf.

Sphinx hawk moth

Lobster moth

Common sailer



Excuse me, I'm changing

To become adult moths, most moth caterpillars spin themselves a cocoon using silk, which comes out of their spinnerets. Inside, they undergo astonishing physical changes.



Silkworms

Silk is produced by most moth caterpillars. But the finest silk is produced by the silkmoth caterpillar, often known as a silkworm. After the caterpillars have spun themselves into a silken cocoon, they are put into boiling water. The silk is removed and spun into threads to create material for clothes.

